



The BRICS Business Council and Business Forums

The BRICS Business Council, composed of 24 council members and supported by over 2,000 committee representatives, is a unique platform for building a multipolar world through business collaboration. As a founding member and Chair of the South African Chapter, I had the privilege of working alongside the co-chairs and their respective business leaders.

The council meetings were held in major capitals such as Beijing, Moscow, and New Delhi. They brought together private companies and state enterprises, strengthening relationships across sectors. Each council was appointed by its respective government, and its recommendations were presented directly to heads of state and ministers, reflecting the council's seniority and strategic importance.

The BRICS Business Forum became a dynamic space for dialogue between business and government, a "who's who" of the Global South. Hosting the forum in Johannesburg and Durban was an honour, allowing South African business communities, city mayors, and regional leaders to engage directly with global partners. These gatherings advanced people-to-people business exchanges and built practical cooperation across industries.

The New Development Bank

The BRICS Business Council, working alongside the heads of state and finance ministers, helped plant the seeds of what would become the New Development Bank (NDB). This was a milestone achievement designed to facilitate investment and economic growth across BRICS countries and beyond.

I was proud to be part of the early discussions that envisioned an independent BRICS bank, not as a rival to other multilateral institutions but as a complement, ensuring that capital could be channelled effectively to the Global South. The NDB today serves nearly half of the world's population, financing sustainable infrastructure, digital inclusion, and energy transformation.

In my capacity as Chairman of the BRICS Business Council, I engaged closely with the NDB's leadership and hosted several of its conferences in South Africa. These discussions deepened the potential for accelerating payment systems, fintech development, and financial inclusion. Yet, I have also acknowledged that South Africa's public and private sectors have not yet fully capitalised on the NDB's opportunities, particularly in infrastructure development such as rail, harbours, and transport logistics.

BRICS Media Forum, Belt and Road News Network

As the Chairman and owner of one of Africa's largest media organisations, I was honoured to serve as Co-Chair of the BRICS Media Forum alongside the President and Chairman of Xinhua and People's Daily News Agencies. Hosting these forums in South Africa on several occasions was a privilege, as they strengthened media cooperation and mutual understanding among BRICS nations.

Additionally, I was delighted to serve on the Belt and Road News Network, helping to foster partnerships in global communication and media collaboration. These engagements underscored the importance of telling our own stories, ensuring that the voices of the Global South are heard in the global narrative.

The Global South and the need for shared humanity

The post–World War II period saw immense economic growth in the West, unprecedented prosperity for some, but not for all. While the Global South made economic strides, the benefits of that growth often failed to reach its people. The emergence of BRICS has accelerated economic inclusion and cooperation across regions.

This can only be a positive force for a shared humanity. For the first time in modern history, the world has the opportunity to eradicate poverty, reduce inequality, and ensure that all people can live with dignity. This is the ultimate promise of BRICS and of an integrated Global South within the global community of nations.